WINTER ACCOUNTS

Reference adaptation for testing

(test kit - opening and final sequences)

Based on the novella by E. J. Harrow

24 September 2026
Scenes 11-34 are outlined in the answer key, not written here.

1 INT. COUNTING HOUSE - VANE & SONS - NIGHT 1

HOLLIN, 1931.

A small room lined with ledgers, their spines dated in white ink, 1893 to 1931.

HALLORAN (74), neat as a column of figures, lifts down the ledger marked 1911. His hands are careful and slow. He opens it at page forty-one.

One line on the page is in a different hand from all the rest: small, upright, exact.

HALLORAN (V.O.)
I kept the accounts of Vane and Sons, Clockmakers, for thirty-one years. And I kept one account false.

He lays his finger beside the line. Not on it.

2 INT. WORKSHOP - VANE & SONS - DAY 2

DECEMBER 1910.

Benches, lathes, a hundred clocks ticking out of step with each other. In the corner, a tall REGULATOR clock in a mahogany case, pendulum swinging slow and grave.

OLD MR. VANE (60s) at his bench, a loupe in his eye, a balance wheel held in steel tweezers.

The tweezers stop moving.

The hundred clocks go on.

AUREL VANE (28) comes in from the yard with a scuttle of coal, talking.

AUREL
Mrs. Ashby's sent round again about the carriage clock, I told her Thursday--

He sees. Puts the scuttle down very gently, as if it might wake someone.

3 INT. WORKSHOP - NEXT DAY 3

Aurel at his father's bench, his father's loupe in his eye, finishing the carriage clock. His hands are his father's hands.

The regulator ticks.

4 EXT. MILL STREET - SNOW - DAY 4

Aurel walks home in the snow. His fist is closed tight.

He stops under a street lamp and opens it: four shillings.

He looks at them a long time.

5 INT. VANE HOUSE - HALL - CONTINUOUS 5

On the hall table, a letter. The envelope is printed NORTHERN COUNTIES BANK. It has been opened.

MIRA VANE (24), in mourning black, stands at the foot of the stairs with the letter in her hand.

MIRA
Two thousand one hundred pounds.

AUREL
It's for the town hall clock.
Father borrowed against the
commission.

MIRA
And the Borough?

AUREL
Pays three thousand on completion.
June. For the Coronation.

MIRA
And until June?

He puts the four shillings on the hall table, one at a time. They both look at them.

6 INT. WORKSHOP - DAY 6

A shape under a dust sheet, taller than a man.

Aurel pulls the sheet away: the TOWN HALL MOVEMENT, half-built. A cast iron frame. Great gunmetal wheels, some cut, some still blank. A thing between a machine and a cathedral.

At the door: SILAS CRASKE (50s), fur-collared coat, very good teeth. He looks at the movement with real admiration.

CRASKE
Your father was the last craftsman in the North. I mean that.

He walks around it slowly.

CRASKE (CONT'D)
I'll give you nine hundred pounds for the firm and the commission. I'll clear the bank. You and your sister can go wherever you like.

AUREL
We'd still owe the bank twelve hundred.

CRASKE
Less than you owe now.

He smiles. Pulls on his gloves.

CRASKE (CONT'D)
Think about it, Mr. Vane. Take your time.
(at the door)
Only -- the bank won't.

7 INT. WORKSHOP - NIGHT 7

Only the regulator's tick now. The other clocks have been let run down.

Aurel stands in front of it. Beside it, Mira, a shawl over her mourning.

Aurel takes out his FATHER'S POCKET WATCH, opens it, and sets it by the regulator. Exactly. The way it has been set every morning for thirty years.

MIRA
It's four minutes slow.

AUREL
It's always been four minutes slow.

MIRA
"A Vane should always be a little behind the world. It keeps us humble."
(beat)
It was the only joke he ever made. He made it every day for thirty years.

Aurel closes the watch. Pockets it.

He picks up a file from the bench and goes to the town hall movement.

MIRA (CONT'D)
Aurel. It's midnight.

He starts to file a tooth on the great escape wheel.

8 INT. MIRA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT 8

Mira in bed, a lap desk on her knees, writing. Through the wall: the rasp of a file. Stop. Rasp.

MIRA (V.O.)
My dearest E. -- Aurel works all night in the shop. I hear the files going at two in the morning, and I lie in bed and think: there is my brother, filing his way out of the poorhouse one tooth at a time.

The file stops. She waits. It starts again.

MIRA (V.O.)
He is so like Father that it frightens me.

9 INT. VANE HOUSE - PARLOUR - DAY 9

MISS PELL (40s), from the bank, very correct, a hat she does not remove. She drinks the good tea. Aurel and Mira opposite.

MISS PELL
The directors will require sight of the firm's ledgers on the first of February. As a formality.

AUREL
Of course.

MISS PELL
If the firm can show payments received against the commission, the directors will be inclined to extend.
(kindly)
If it cannot, I'm afraid they will call the loan.

She sets her cup down without a sound.

MIRA (V.O.)
It is extraordinary how kind people can be while telling you they will take your house.

10 INT. COUNTING HOUSE - NIGHT 10

JANUARY 31ST.

The ledger open under one lamp. A pen. A bottle of ink. Aurel sits where Halloran sits.

From the next room, the regulator: tick. Tick.

He turns to page forty-one. Uncaps the ink.

He dips the pen.

CUT TO BLACK.

SCENES 11-34: SEE REFERENCE OUTLINE IN THE ANSWER KEY

35 INT. WORKSHOP - DAWN 35

JUNE 22ND. CORONATION DAY.

Aurel in his father's good black coat. He opens the pocket watch and sets it by the regulator. Habit. He doesn't look at what he's doing. He's looking at the empty space where the movement stood.

36 INT. TOWN HALL - CLOCK ROOM - MORNING 36

The finished movement, alive, beating inside the tower. Light through the back of the south dial.

Aurel alone. He checks the pocket watch. Stops the pendulum with his hand. Moves the hands. Starts it again.

A perfect machine, perfectly set.

37 EXT. TOWN SQUARE - DAY 37

Bunting. Two thousand people. The HOLLIN SILVER BAND plays "Zadok the Priest" slightly too fast.

On the platform: the MAYOR, the corporation, Aurel. In the crowd: Mira. Halloran. At the foot of the platform steps, Craske, gloved.

The Mayor raises his hand. The band stops. The square goes quiet.

Every face turns up to the south dial. The minute hand is a breath from twelve.

It touches twelve.

Nothing.

A murmur. A child laughs.

Aurel takes out the pocket watch. Eleven fifty-six.

He looks at it. Then up at the dial. Then at the watch again.

He closes the watch.

The murmur becomes laughter. It spreads across the square.

The south dial: four minutes past twelve.

The clock strikes. Twelve long strokes, perfect, beautiful, rolling across the rooftops of Hollin, four minutes behind the world.

38 EXT. TOWN SQUARE - PLATFORM STEPS - CONTINUOUS 38

Aurel comes down. Craske is waiting. He is the only one in the square not laughing.

He holds out a folded paper.

CRASKE
The treasurer's certificate of payments received. I'm afraid it doesn't agree with your ledger. The bank has a copy. So do the police.
(and he means it)
I'm sorry, Mr. Vane. Truly. It's a beautiful clock.

Aurel doesn't take the paper. He looks past Craske into the crowd.

He can't find Mira.

He finds Halloran, at the back by the fountain, hat in his hands. Their eyes meet.

Halloran knew. Aurel sees that he knew.

Neither of them moves.

39 INT. WORKSHOP - NIGHT 39

The regulator ticks.

Aurel, still in the black coat. He stands in front of it a long time.

He opens the case. Puts out his hand. Stops the pendulum.

Silence. For the first time in thirty years.

On the bench, he leaves a folded note. On the outside: MIRA.

40 EXT. MILL-RACE - NIGHT 40

The path above the town. Summer dark. The mill-race runs black and fast where in April there was ice.

Aurel walks up the path in his father's coat.

He stops on the bank. The same place he stood with Mira.

The water is very loud.

He stands there.

41 INT. MIRA'S BEDROOM - DAWN 41

Mira, dressed, not slept. She holds the note, open. She reads it again.

A heavy KNOCK below. Men's voices. "Police."

She folds the note small. Puts it inside her dress.

42 EXT. MILL-RACE - SLUICE - DAY 42

SPRING 1912.

The ice going off the water in grey plates.

The MILLER'S BOY (12) hauls something from the sluice gate with a hook: a man's black coat, sodden, of an old-fashioned cut.

The MILLER takes it from him. Looks at it. Looks down at the town.

43 INT. MILL - DAY 43

The Miller feeds the coat into the stove. Shuts the door on it.

44 INT. COUNTING HOUSE - NIGHT 44

1931.

Old Halloran writes a last line in his own hand beneath the entries for 1911. Blots it.

HALLORAN (V.O.)
In the autumn of 1912 an American collector bought the firm, the house and the debts outright, for more than all of them were worth, and put the Vane name back on the door.
(beat)
So none of it needed to happen.

He closes the ledger.

45 EXT. TOWN SQUARE - DAY 45

1931. The town hall clock. People cross the square without looking up.

Halloran, with a stick, stops by the fountain. Takes out his watch. Twelve o'clock.

He waits.

The clock strikes: four minutes late. Twelve slow strokes.

He puts his watch away without correcting it.

HALLORAN (V.O.)
It does not balance. I find that I can close the book regardless.

FADE OUT.